



THE BIG CHALLENGERS
H.D. Kumaraswamy taking out JD(S)'s *pancharathna yatra* on Jan. 30, (right) Karnataka Congress chief D.K. Shivakumar addressing a rally in Mandya on Jan. 27

has been able to attract Vokkaliga voters in Bengaluru and other urban centres, the rural populace has been out of bounds for long. Hence, over the past couple of years, the BJP's Vokkaliga leaders, such as C.N. Ashwath Narayana, C.T. Ravi, R. Ashoka and K. Sudhakar among others, have been trying to facilitate the party's penetration into the interiors—this time around, the BJP is hopeful of making inroads into the Vokkaliga heartland.

But the task doesn't appear easy either. Last month, the BJP faced an embarrassment of sorts when posters saying 'Go Back'—apparently put up by party workers—greeted R. Ashoka, the newly appointed minister-in-charge of Mandya district. Currently, the BJP holds 15 out of the 28 assembly seats in Bengaluru—hence, the city figures as one of the key priorities for the party ahead of the election. But the neighbouring districts, such as Ramanagara, Mandya, Hassan, Kolar, Chikkaballapura and even Tumakuru and Mysuru, have been its handicap—out of the 51 seats in these districts, it won only eight in 2018. (Currently, its tally is 11 following defections and bypolls.)

Given that the BJP has a significant presence across other regions of Karnataka, it needs to ensure that these southern districts are conquered so that it can reach safe numbers. But the tussle here, traditionally, has always been between the JD(S) and Congress.

That's the reason even Congress leaders, in their recent rallies, have been appealing to voters to shun the JD(S). As political observers read the situation, the ability of both the BJP and Congress to cross the halfway mark of 112 in the 224-member Karnataka assembly depends on how the JD(S) performs. A strong showing by the JD(S) in the Old Mysore region can potentially produce a hung assembly.

At a rally in Mandya on January 27, D.K. Shivakumar, president of the Karnataka unit of the Congress, reminded voters that his party had supported the JD(S) in 2018 and made Gowda's son H.D. Kumaraswamy the chief minister in order to prevent the BJP from coming to power. "But they could not save the government," he said, referring to the defections orchestrated by the BJP that toppled the Congress-JD(S) coalition in 2019. Making an emotional appeal as a Vokkaliga himself, Shivakumar inverted the BJP argument—saying any vote to the JD(S) will only help the BJP return to power.

FEARING A HUNG ASSEMBLY, BOTH BJP AND CONGRESS URGE VOTERS TO SHUN JD(S) IN ITS VOKKALIGA STRONGHOLD

Meanwhile, having finished the first leg of his election tour in the Old Mysore region, Kumaraswamy is now taking his *pancharathna yatra* further afield into regions where the JD(S) doesn't have much of a support base. His campaign is focusing on issues like education, employment, housing and health. A functionary says the party, after several defections, has been trying to rebuild its cadre over the past couple of years at the booth level. The JD(S) was also first off the block with a list of candidates. Given the stakes involved and the chancy nature of the game, the battle for the Vokkaliga heartland will be a key one to watch as Karnataka heads to the polls. ■